

Gussie Busch took over the company in 1946 after the death of his older brother, Adolphus Busch III. Gussie was a rough-around-the-edges character who married four times. (This was a trend followed by many Busch men.) He bought the St. Louis Cardinals in 1953 and built the first and second Busch stadiums for them to play in. He also restored Anheuser-Busch as the nation's number one brewer. And in 1959, Anheuser-Busch opened the Busch Gardens amusement park in Tampa, Florida.

In 1975, Gussie Busch's eldest son, August "Auggie" Busch III, forced his father's resignation as chief executive. Auggie accused his father of ignoring the growth of the competition. Auggie wanted to fight an advertising war against their largest rival, the Miller Brewing Company.

The problem was that all this spending whittled down the family's ownership of Anheuser-Busch to just 12.5 percent at the time of Gussie's death. Worse, his death unlocked trusts that allowed family members to sell off even more stock over the coming years.

When Auggie took over the reins at Anheuser-Busch, he took the company public. He used the proceeds to build 11 new breweries and support one of the biggest advertising budgets in the country. By the 1990s, Anheuser-Busch sold one of every two beers in the United States.

But this growth had come at great expense. The Busch family's ownership stake shrank to only 4 percent of the company. But in St. Louis they were still treated as if they owned the place. And Auggie's eldest son, August Busch IV, was born the scion of an American business dynasty.

But by most accounts, he was a reckless party boy. As a college student at the University of Arizona, he left the scene of an accident that left a 22-year-old girl dead. His father splurged on a team of lawyers and private investigators to extricate him. After an eight-month investigation, the authorities declined to press charges.

In 1985, while at St. Louis University, he had a run-in with police. And officers shot out a tire on his Mercedes. When they found out who he was, they ended up changing his tire. They did arrest him on assault charges. But a jury acquitted him.

August IV started as an assistant to the brewmaster at Anheuser-Busch and climbed through the ranks. He had some success in the marketing department, putting together some successful advertising campaigns for